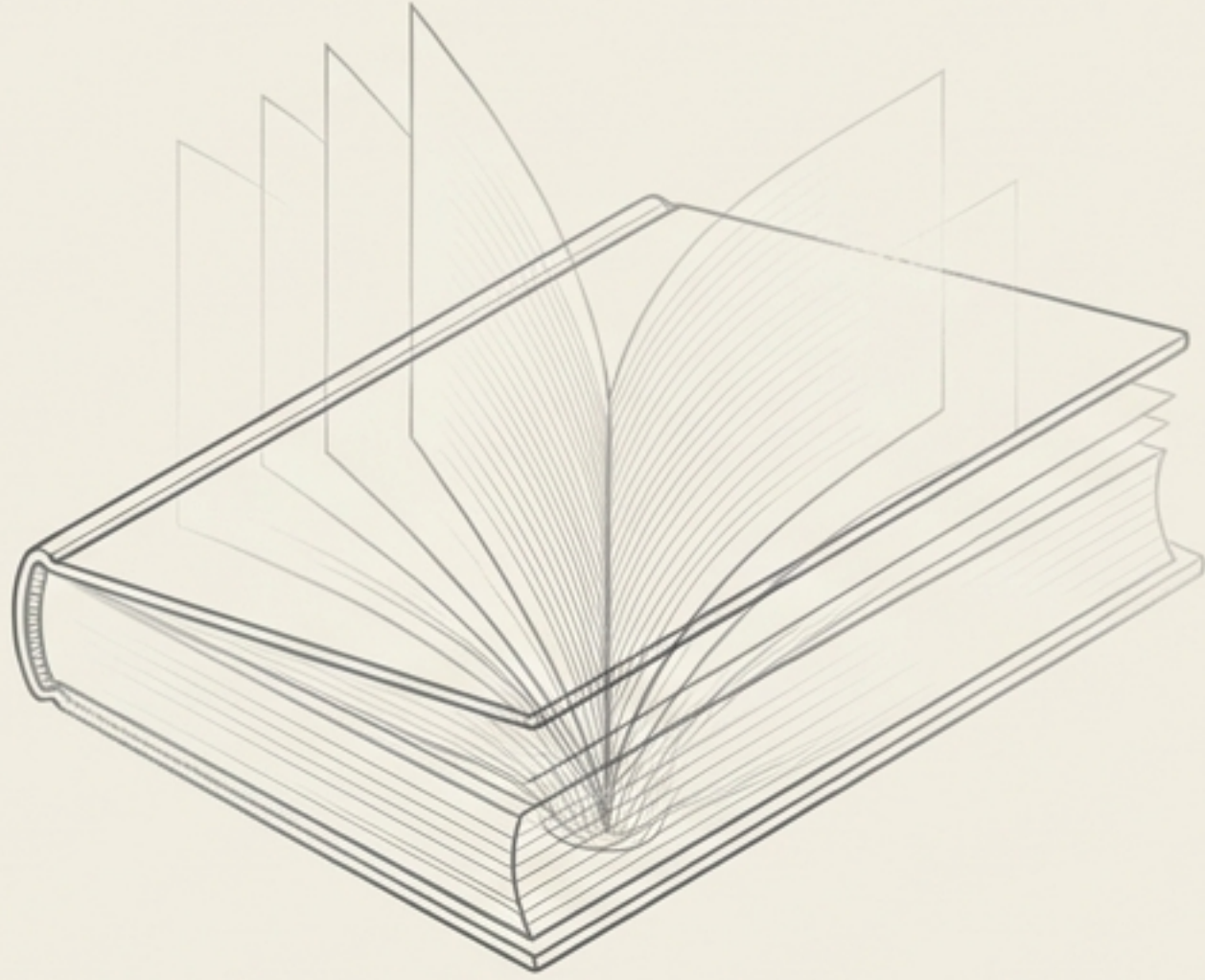


Terminal and Traversal

A Theory of What Reading Actually Costs

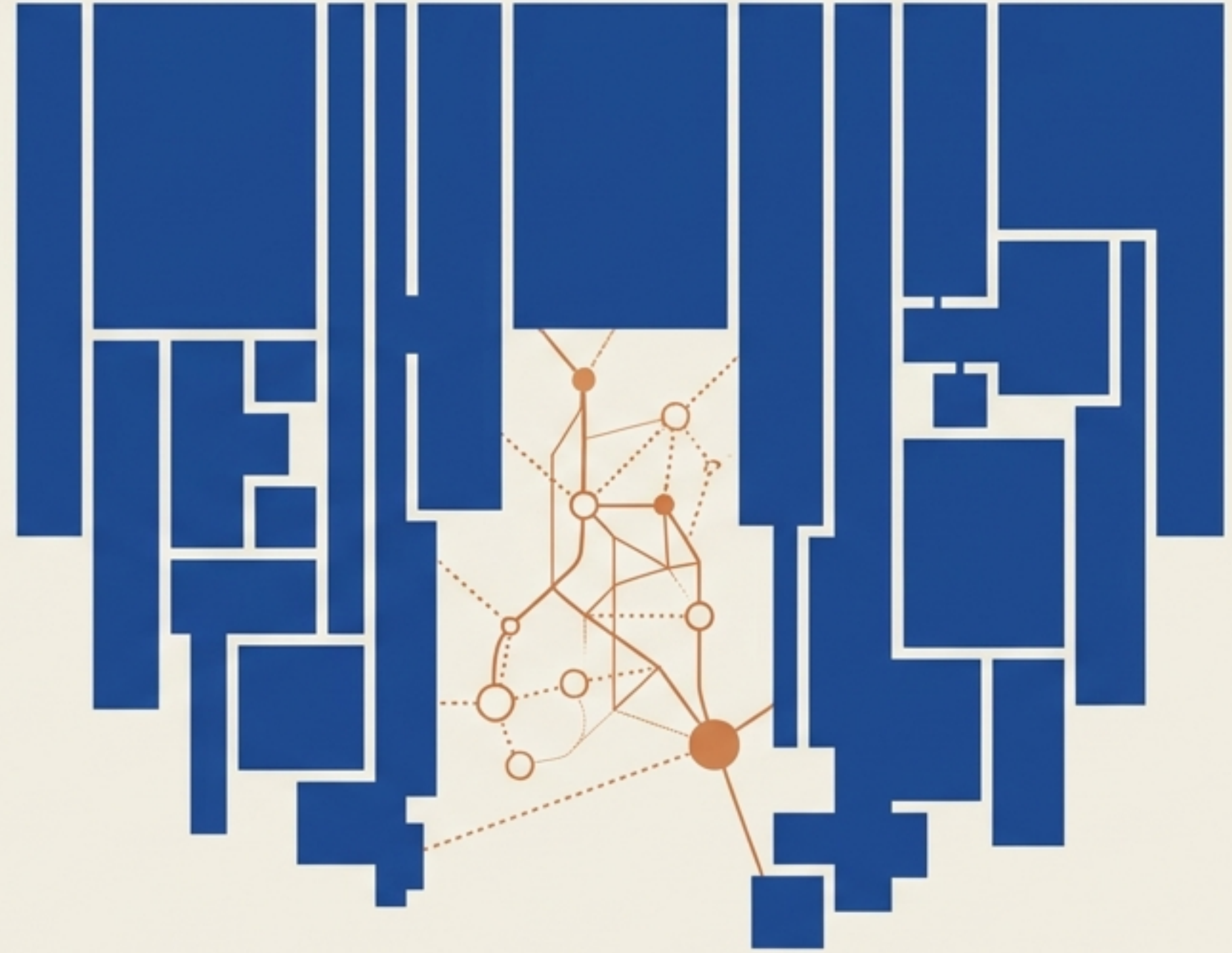
Based on the 2026 framework by Flyxion.

We are asking the wrong question about the decline of reading.



The Diagnosis:

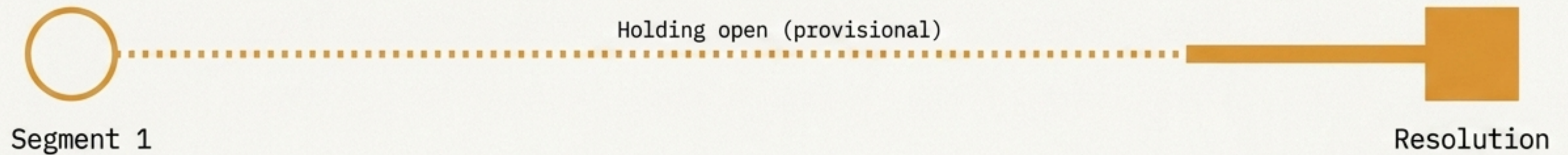
Society is dissolving into postliteracy as reading declines uniformly.



The Reality:

Text has not disappeared; it is more abundant than in any prior era. What is contracting is a very specific, expensive cognitive engagement with text. The question is not if we are reading, but what cognitive operations we are no longer performing.

The architecture of holding an interpretation open.



Aqra'a (Arabic causative root q-r-hamza):

1. To cause one to read.
2. To cause a thing to be versified.
3. To cause one to draw near.
4. To be delayed.
5. To hold a thing until a month has passed and its meaning can be determined.

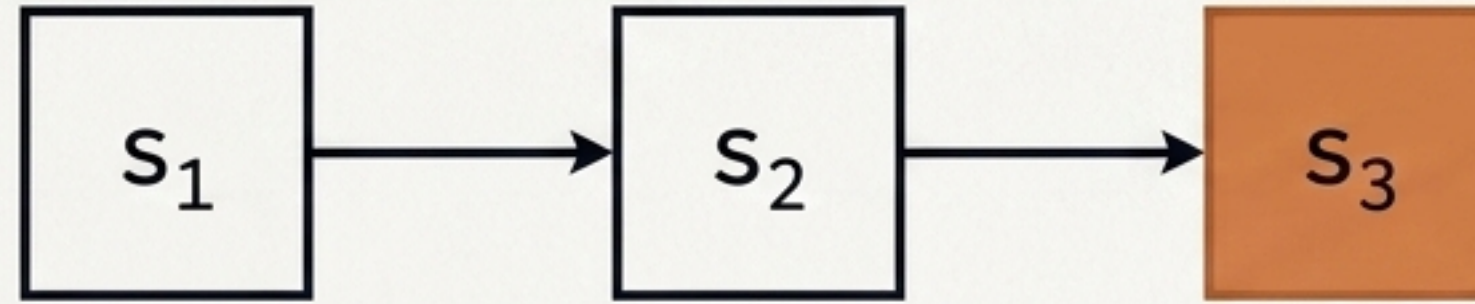
Beneath these senses lies a single cognitive structure: to hold something in a provisional state until a later point resolves what it was.

Reading is not one activity. It is two distinct modes of processing.

	Recognition	Traversal
Mechanism	Classify against an existing predictive model.	Hold an interpretation in a provisional state pending later revision.
Speed	High-speed, uniform.	Variable, gated by local predictability (surprisal).
State at First Contact	Settled and closed.	Unresolved and suspended.
Ideal Use-Case	Log files, routine emails, weather reports.	Philosophical arguments, legal opinions, mechanical reasoning.

The Load-Bearing Criterion

State A (Intact):



State B (Deleted):

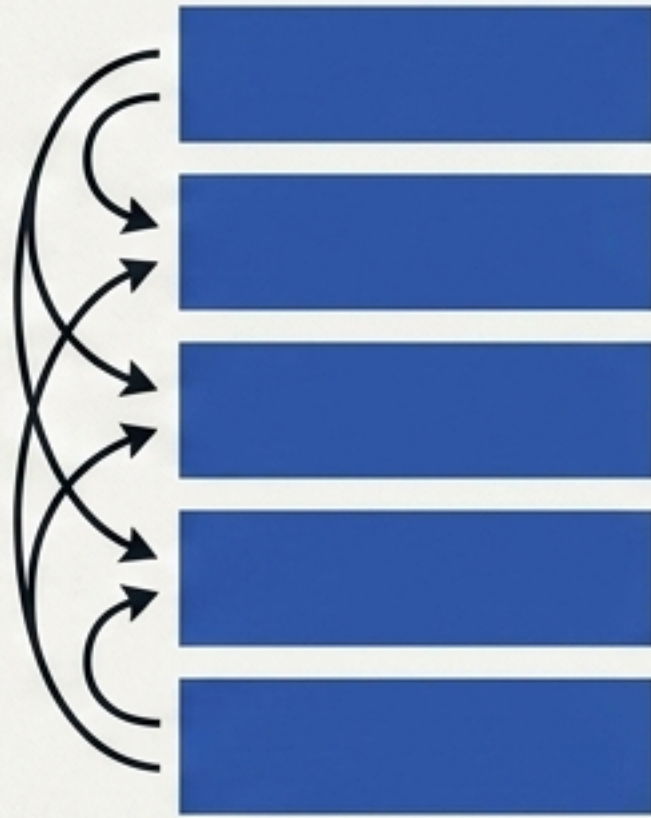


A segment s_i is load-bearing if removing it changes the set of admissible interpretations for a later segment s_j .

$$I(s_j \mid s_1 \dots s_i \dots) \neq I(s_j \mid s_1 \dots \hat{s}_i \dots)$$

Traversal structure exists exactly to the degree that later material performs an operation on an earlier interpretation, rather than just adding a new fact to a list.

Terminal vs. Traversal-Dependent Texts



Terminal Texts

- Contain zero load-bearing segments.
- Order is arbitrary.
- Every segment is fully resolved locally.
- Example: A shopping list, a phonebook.

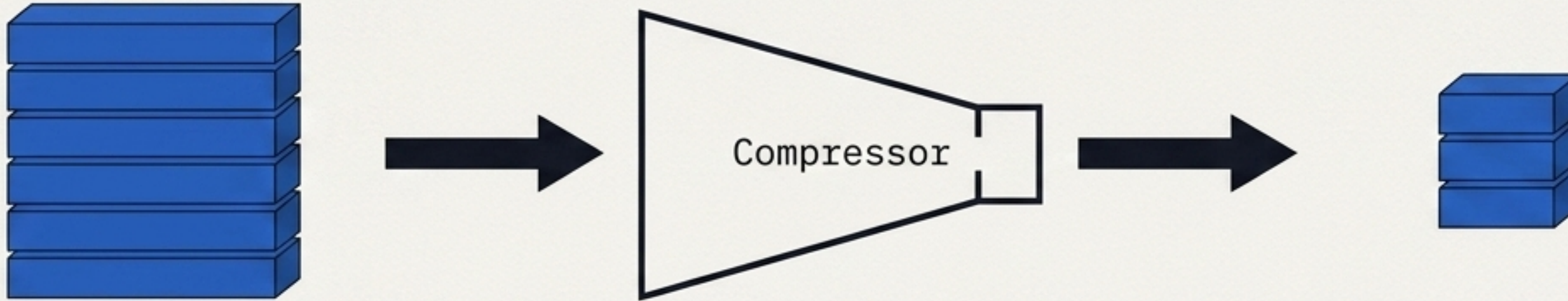


Traversal-Dependent Texts

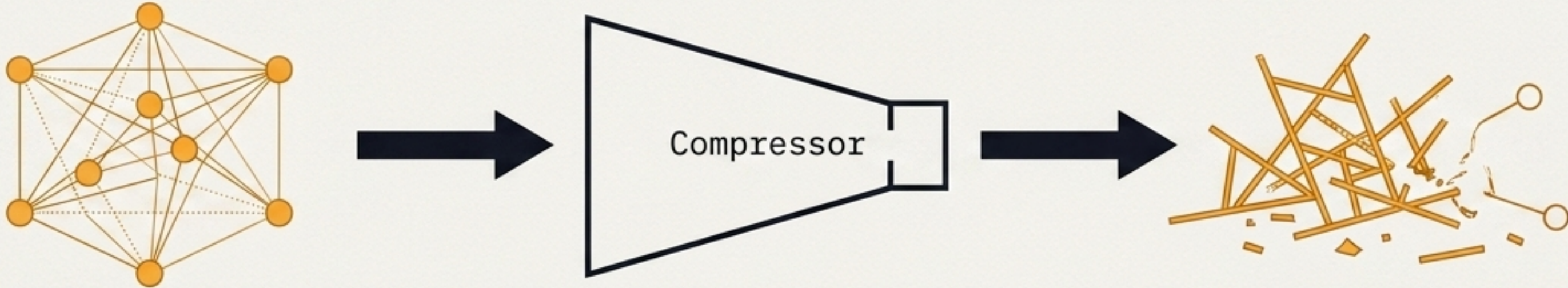
- Defined by the trajectory through which their contents become admissible.
- No list of endpoints can substitute for having traveled the path.
- Example: A mathematical proof, a novel.

Why compression fails selectively.

Compressing a Terminal text shrinks the object perfectly.

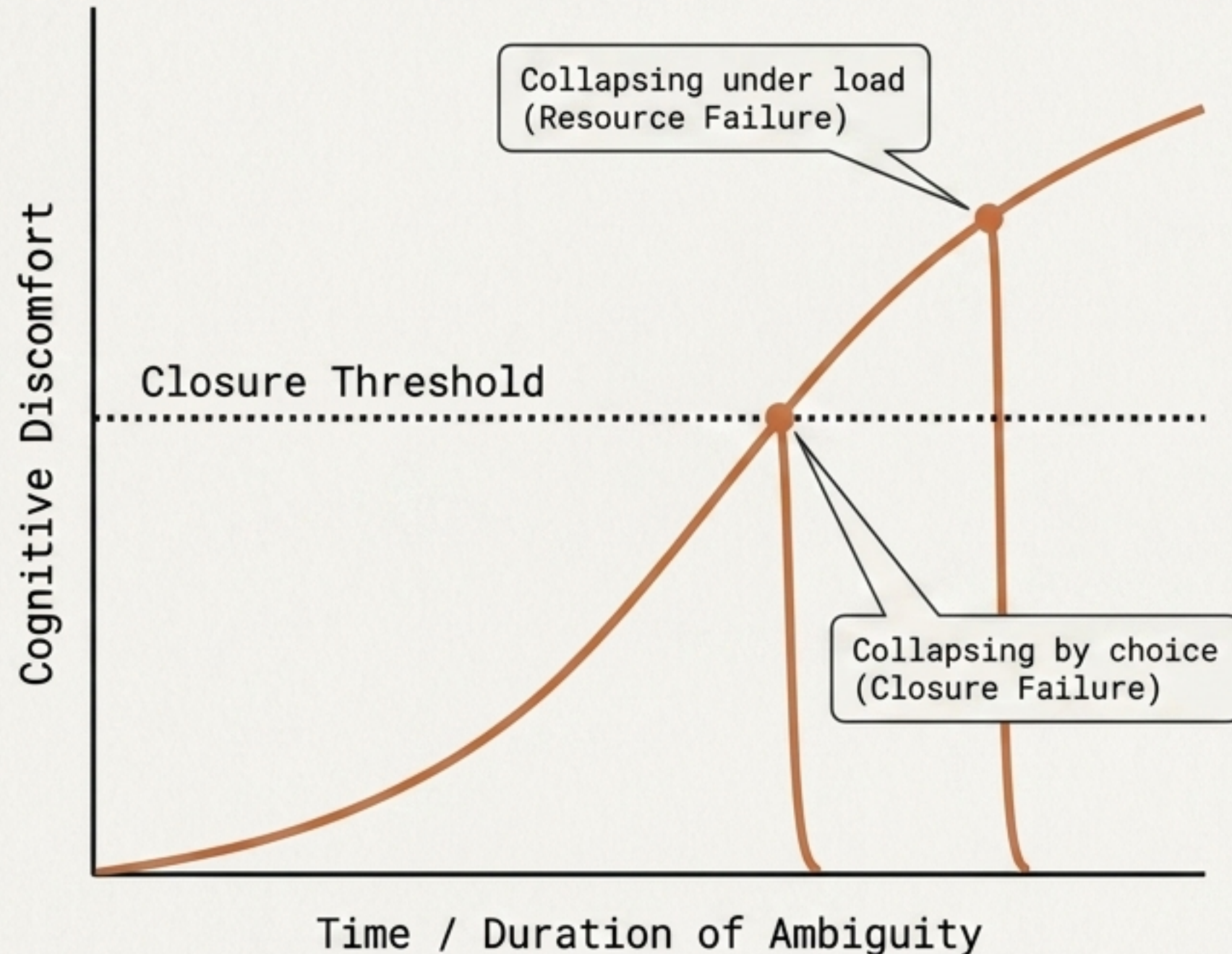


Compressing a Traversal text destroys the object entirely.



A summarizer optimized to preserve propositions cannot distinguish a load-bearing segment from a decorative one.
A reader receiving only the summary of an argument holds the proposition without the operation that produced it.

The Threshold of Collapse



Traversal fails in two ways that look identical but have opposite causes.

1. **Resource Failure:** The system simply runs out of capacity (working memory, time).
2. **Closure Failure:** Unresolved ambiguity becomes psychologically costlier than premature commitment.

Expertise: Careful readers do not necessarily have more memory; they have a trained, elevated closure threshold, tolerating discomfort longer to avoid snapping to premature certainty.

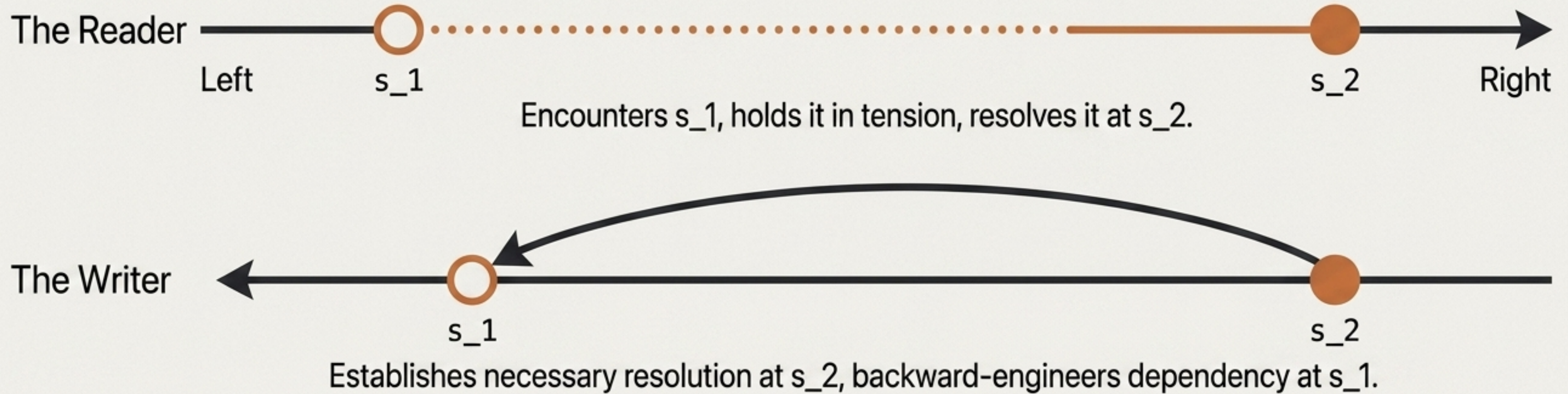
Relevance is retroactive.



Load-bearing status is negotiated between a text and a changing reader. Details classified as noise on first encounter can be reclassified as signal years later when experience reshapes the predictive model.

The true nature of notes: Curatorial acts (bookmarking, notes) are not records of what mattered. They are bets, made under uncertainty, about what will become load-bearing to a future predictive model that doesn't yet exist.

The Mirror of Writing

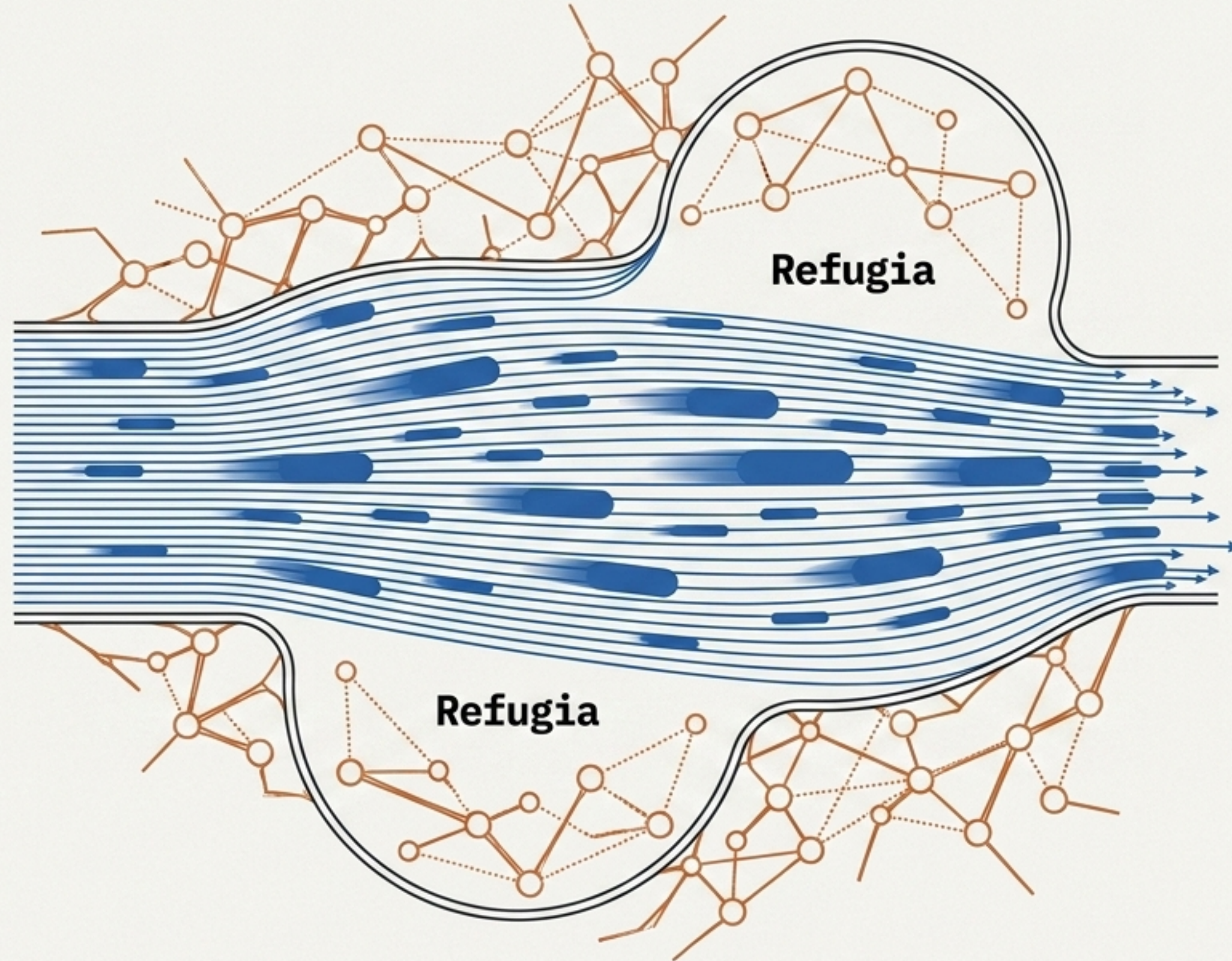


To compose a load-bearing segment is to place a dependency that does not yet exist for the reader. A well-built argument is not written forward. The writer simultaneously constructs the earlier state as it will be experienced, while holding the later revision that gives it purpose.

The AI Question: LLMs generate text via local, forward-only prediction. Whether a forward-predicting system can genuinely author backward-looking, load-bearing traversal structure remains the defining question of generated media.

Selection Pressure and Refugia

Traversal-dependent objects are not being replaced; they are being in environments that reward fast, frictionless circulation. Recognition-stable objects survive partial attention and context-stripping. Traversal objects do not.



Refugia: Environments where the ordinary transmission advantages of recognition-stable objects are locally suspended (e.g., book clubs, slow media, long-form journals).

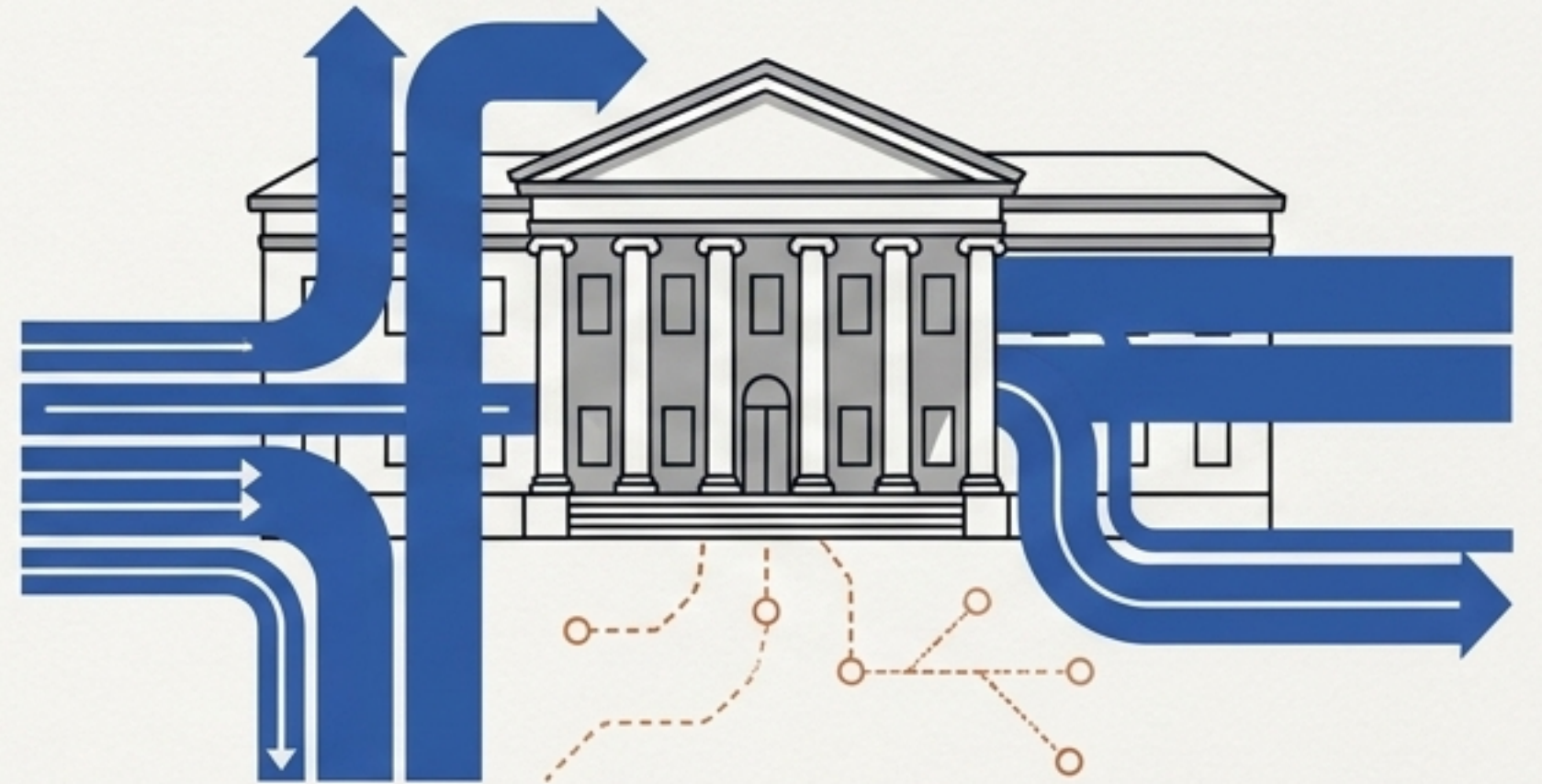
The scrolls are not lost. They are outcompeted.

The Myth of Physical Loss



The contemporary crisis is not physical loss (texts ceasing to exist). The archive remains fully intact and retrievable.

The Reality of Selection Pressure



Large-scale text generation does not destroy traversal texts; it dramatically increases the volume of the channel. In a crowded channel, the advantage shifts heavily toward whatever is cheapest to classify and pass along. A larger recognition-stable majority drowns out a traversal-dependent minority.

The Archive and The Trail

The Individual Response:

We can adapt. We can offload provisional states into notes, spend time in refugia, and practice raising our cognitive closure thresholds by delaying resolution.

The Civilizational Reality:

An organism adapting to a shrinking habitat does not mean the habitat is healthy.



A society loses traversal when the institutions that made dependency-tracking an ordinary part of life require deliberate resistance to maintain. The paths through the archive are still walkable. They have simply stopped being roads, and become trails.